WEST BENGAL

MAMATA TIGHTENS HER GRIP

By Romita Datta



Early this month, the Trinamool Congress government in West Bengal strode past the one-year mark of its third term in office. Yet its gait in the past year has become sluggish, its shape loose and baggy, signs of physical decay breaking out every so often. The diagnosis has been there for some time: an unwieldy growth born not of the pull of ideology, but of squeezing out Opposition space in the state and admitting all and sundry in the party without judgement. For Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, it's a challenge to reckon with.

This malaise is at the source of much of the Trinamool government's problems—a spate of crimes, including rapes, allegedly involving TMC members, open and violent infighting amongst party factions, a string of CBI probes against leaders, including in cases of post-poll violence and the teachers' recruitment scam. All this has created an impression of lawlessness. Mamata's first line of defence against this is logical—there will impurities in a party that so dominates a state. "What to do, what's the use of pulling up TMC. In Bengal everyone is TMC," she had said in response to some rape cases being allegedly linked to party members. However, deep down, she is aware of the need to tighen party structure and reimpose discipline.

With this objective in mind, Mamata held meetings with administrative heads—district magistrates, SPs and party leaders—and senior leaders. The purpose was to lay down a blueprint of governance and the future road map for the party. At the meeting on April 27, the diktat was clear. "The party won't allow...corruption. Take stern action against those involved in extorting money for fake appointments, looting in chit funds, illegal sand mining.... When I am saying each and everyone, it's each and everyone."

"Can she really stop sand/stone mining or coal mining? They are the mainstay of TMC's resource mobilisation. Bagtui has exposed the politics-crime nexus. That she has to ask the administration to be impartial proves the contrary practice and that people need to be convinced of her neutrality," says former HoD of political science, Calcutta University, Sovonlal Dutta Gupta. Indeed, the March 21 carnage in Bagtui—the fall-out of a revenge killing in which nine people were burnt alive over the share of illegal sand and stone mining—has embarrassed the party.

"Arrest of district leader Anarul Hossain (the Bagtui accused) might not be a big thing, but making leaders accountable might send a message to her unruly brigade that she is uncompromising on crime and corruption," says professor emeritus of Presidency University, Prashant Ray. "For a party without an ideology, cohesive bonding is missing. Mamata's charisma had been the cementing factor. Now that has lost its sheen," Dutta Gupta adds.

THOUGH YOUNG LEADERS HAVE GROUPED AROUND ABHISHEK, MAMATA HAS SHOWN SHE HAS THE LAST SAY



SUBIR HALDER

With corruption and law and order scandals nibbling at her heels and cries by the Opposition BJP demanding president's rule, Mamata has had to act. As an immediate step, she has introduced the sequel to her 'Didi ke bolo' (tell sister) public grievance redressal programme in early May so people can register grievances directly with the CMO.